6 DEVOTIONALS ON NAHUM

A Refuge in the Day of Distress

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How to use this booklet

1. Set aside about 15 to 20 minutes for each day, ideally somewhere quiet.
2. Read the Scripture passage first, slowly – aloud, if you can. It stands at the start of each devotional.
3. "Digging Deeper" takes you into the context and the language of the original text. "Living It Out" asks what it means for you.
4. Take your time with the questions. You may want to write your answers down.
5. Close with the prayer – and with your own words.

A Refuge in the Day of Distress
6 devotionals on Nahum

Scripture: own translation from the Hebrew (Masoretic Text) by Dr. Johannes A. Nortjé. Verse numbers follow the Hebrew text.

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Read online: https://hannesnortje.github.io/devotionals/nahum/en/

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DAY 1

The Majesty of God: Slow to Anger, a Refuge in Distress

SCRIPTURE

Nahum 1:1–8

[1] An oracle concerning Nineveh. The book of the vision of Nahum the
Elkoshite.

[2] A jealous God, one who takes vengeance, is the LORD;
the LORD takes vengeance and is full of wrath.
The LORD takes vengeance on his adversaries
and holds it against his enemies.
[3] The LORD is slow to anger and great in power,
and the LORD will surely not acquit the guilty.
In whirlwind and in storm is his way,
and clouds are the dust of his feet.
[4] He rebukes the sea and makes it dry,
and all the rivers he dries up.
Bashan and Carmel wither,
and the blossom of Lebanon withers.
[5] The mountains shake because of him,
and the hills melt away;
the earth rises up before his face,
the world and all who live in it.
[6] Before his fury who can stand?
Who can rise up against his burning anger?
His wrath pours out like fire,
and the rocks are torn down by him.
[7] The LORD is good,
a refuge in the day of distress;
he knows those who shelter in him.
[8] But with a flood that passes over
he will make a full end of her place,
and his enemies he will pursue into darkness.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Welcome to this in-depth journey through the book of **Nahum**. Nahum is one of the shorter prophetic books of the Old Testament (only three chapters), yet it is a powerful, poetic masterpiece focused on God's sovereignty, his just judgement on evil, and his unshakeable faithfulness as a refuge for his children. Over six days we will work through the text verse by verse.

(A note on verse numbers: we follow the Hebrew text. Chapter 1 is numbered the same in English Bibles, but our 2:1 is English 1:15, and from 2:2 onward English Bibles are one verse lower.)

To understand the book of Nahum, we have to put ourselves in the ancient Near East of the seventh century BC (roughly between 663 and 612 BC). In this period the Assyrian Empire was the undisputed world power, and **Nineveh** was its dazzling, seemingly invincible capital.

About a century before Nahum, the prophet Jonah had gone to Nineveh and preached repentance. The city repented, and God spared it. But within a few generations Nineveh slid back into an even worse state of extreme cruelty, idolatry and bloodshed. The Assyrians were notorious for their psychological warfare and their barbaric torture of conquered peoples. They had already carried the northern kingdom of Israel into exile in 722 BC, and they constantly threatened and extorted Judah. To the small, defenceless nation of Judah it looked as if evil sat on the throne and God was silent.

It is in this dark hour that God calls **Nahum**. The whole book is a prophetic message that God is going to judge the cruel oppressor (Nineveh) – which brings deep comfort and relief to God's oppressed people.

Nahum opens his book (verses 2–8) with a majestic **theophany** (a visible appearing of God's glory in nature), which in the original Hebrew takes the form of a partial acrostic poem (an alphabetic psalm).

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **Nahum (*Nachum* – נַחוּם):** The prophet's name means "**comfort**" or "**comforter**". The name is already the message: God's judgement on the oppressor is comfort for the oppressed.
- **A jealous God (El *qanno'* – אֵל קַנּוֹא):** "Jealous" here has nothing to do with petty human envy. It speaks of the fiery, protective love of a covenant God who refuses to stand by while his bride (his people) is destroyed or his honour is trampled by idols and tyrants.
- **One who takes vengeance (*noqem* – נֹקֵם):** Three times in a single verse the text says that the LORD "takes vengeance" (the participle *noqem*, from *naqam*).
- **Slow to anger (*erekh appayim* – אֶרֶךְ אַפַּיִם):** Literally *"long of nostrils"* – a picture of someone who breathes deeply and does not quickly become angry. These are exactly the words Jonah uses of God in Jonah 4:2: *"a gracious and compassionate God, slow to anger and abounding in faithful love"*.
- **Refuge (*ma'oz* – מָעוֹז):** The word for "**refuge**" means a strong place, a fortress (from the root *'azaz*, to be strong) – and early on it was linked with taking refuge.
- **Knows (*yodea'* – יֹדֵעַ, from *yada'*):** The word for "**knows**" means far more than intellectual knowledge; it speaks of intimate, personal care and a covenant relationship.
- **The acrostic pattern:** In verses 2–8 the lines begin, more or less, with the successive letters of the Hebrew alphabet – from *aleph* (El, v. 2) to roughly the middle of the alphabet, with a few gaps. The form itself says: God's majesty is ordered and complete.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's holy jealousy and vengeance (v. 2):** When the text says three times in one verse that the LORD takes vengeance, it does not mean that God loses control in a fit of rage. It means that God is the supreme Judge of the universe, who will restore justice and righteousness. If God did not punish evil, he could not be perfectly good and just.

2. **The balance between patience and justice (v. 3):** In verse 3 Nahum draws on God's self-revelation to Moses in Exodus 34:6–7: *"The* LORD *is slow to anger"*. Since Jonah's day God had given Nineveh more than a hundred years to turn from its cruelty! Yet his patience is no sign of weakness or indifference. He is *"great in power, and the* LORD *will surely not acquit the guilty."* God's patience has a purpose (to give opportunity for repentance), but it also has a limit.

3. **The Creator's sovereignty over nature and nations (vv. 3b–6):** Assyria boasted of its military might, its horses, its chariots and its massive city walls. Nahum shows how small human power is next to the Creator. The fearsome storms are merely the vehicle he rides on, and the thick thunderclouds are nothing but *"the dust of his feet"*. The most fertile regions of the world of that time – Bashan (known for its pastures), Carmel (known for vineyards and orchards) and Lebanon (known for its mighty cedar forests) – wither at his single word. If the mountains shake and the rocks are torn down before his holiness, how can an earthly kingdom imagine it will stand against him?

4. **The anchor verse: the double character of God's judgement (vv. 7–8):** Verse 7 is the beating heart of the whole book of Nahum: **"The LORD is good, a refuge in the day of distress; he knows those who shelter in him."** Notice the contrast between verse 7 and verse 8. For those who flee to God in humility, he is an unshakeable fortress (*ma'oz*) in the middle of the storm. But for those who rebel against him in pride and oppress others (Nineveh), he is *"a flood that passes over"*, sweeping away their false security. The same God who is a consuming fire to evil is a safe refuge for his children.

Living It Out

In our modern lives we often find ourselves in a position much like that of the believers in Judah. We look at a world full of injustice, corruption, violence and abuse of power – or we face personal "Assyrians": overwhelming crises, unfair treatment, or spiritual attacks that seem too great to overcome.

Nahum 1:1–8 gives us three indispensable anchors for our daily walk:

- **Let go of the burden of your own revenge and bitterness:** When we are treated unjustly, our natural reaction is to hit back or to nurse bitterness in our hearts. Nahum reminds us that the judgement seat belongs to God. Because he promises to defend the innocent and to leave no injustice unpunished, we can leave our case in his hands (Romans 12:19). We do not have to be eaten up by resentment, for the Judge of all the earth sees everything.
- **Don't confuse God's patience with his absence:** Sometimes we wonder, "*Lord, why don't you step in right now?*" Verse 3 teaches us that God is "slow to anger". His timing is driven by wisdom and grace, not by haste. When the wicked seem to prosper, remember that the clouds are only the dust of God's feet – he is still on his way and fully in control.
- **Choose your fortress deliberately in the day of distress:** Verse 7 does not promise that believers will never go through a "day of distress". On the contrary, it assumes that such days will come. The question is where you run when the storm breaks. Do we run to human solutions, to fear, to control or to distraction? Or do we flee to the *ma'oz* – the fortress of God's presence – knowing that he *knows* us by name and cares for us intimately?

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Is there a situation of injustice or hardship in your life where it feels right now as if the "Ninevehs" of this world have the upper hand? How does the picture of God's power in verses 3–6 change your view of that

problem?

- What is your first reaction when a "day of distress" (a crisis, anxiety or disappointment) comes your way? What would it mean for you in practice today to shelter in the Lord instead of trying to carry the load alone?
- How does the truth that *"he knows those who shelter in him"* (v. 7) comfort you today in your particular circumstances?

Prayer

> *Heavenly Father, Ruler of the universe and Judge of all nations, I bow today in reverence before your majesty. When I look at the storms of this life and the injustice in the world around me, my heart often grows small and anxious. Thank you that your Word in Nahum lifts my eyes again to see your greatness. Before you the mountains shake, and the greatest powers of this world are like worthless dust at your feet.*
>
> *Lord, I confess that I sometimes mistake your patience for slowness, and that I try to fight my own battles in my own strength. Today I lay every scrap of bitterness, fear and uncertainty at your feet. I declare again from Nahum 1:7: You are good! You are my only true refuge and mountain stronghold in the day of distress. Thank you that you do not merely see me from a distance, but know me intimately, understand my heart and hold me safely in your hands. Teach me to walk in your rest today, however hard the storm winds blow outside. In the mighty name of Jesus Christ, my Rock and Redeemer. Amen.*

DAY 2

The End of Affliction and the Feet of One Who Brings Good News

SCRIPTURE

Nahum 1:9 – 2:1

9 What are you devising against the LORD?
He is making a full end;
distress will not rise up a second time.
10 For even if they are like tangled thorns
and drunk as with their drink,
they are devoured like dry stubble, completely.
11 From you has come out
one who devises evil against the LORD,
one who counsels what is worthless.
12 Thus says the LORD:
Though they are at full strength and ever so many,
even so they will be shorn and pass away.
I have afflicted you;
I will afflict you no more.
13 And now I will break his yoke from off you
and tear your bonds apart.
14 But concerning you the LORD has commanded:
Nothing more will be sown that bears your name.
From the house of your gods I will cut off
carved image and cast image;
I will make your grave,
for you weigh nothing.
1 Look, on the mountains
the feet of one who brings good news,
who announces peace!
Keep your festivals, Judah,
pay your vows!
For never again will the worthless one
pass through you;
he is cut off completely. (*English Bibles*: 1:15)

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

(A note on verse numbers: today's passage is 1:9–2:1 in the Hebrew text, which we follow; English Bibles number it 1:9–15. Our 2:1 is English 1:15.)

In the first half of chapter 1 Nahum painted a breathtaking picture of God's cosmic majesty. Now, in 1:9–2:1 (English 1:9–15), the camera moves from the heavenly throne room straight to the concrete crisis on the ground: the triangle between the proud Assyrian Empire, the broken people of Judah, and the sovereign God of Israel.

What makes this passage so fascinating as literature is the way the prophet's voice keeps switching between two audiences. He speaks in turn to **Nineveh** (in a tone of inescapable judgement) and to **Judah** (in a tone of tender comfort and liberation). For more than a century Judah had lived under the heavy political, economic and spiritual shadow of Assyria. They had to pay crushing tribute, their towns were laid waste, and in 701 BC the Assyrian king Sennacherib even besieged Jerusalem and openly mocked the living God (2 Kings 18–19).

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **Distress (*tsarah* – צָרָה, v. 9):** "*Distress will not rise up a second time.*" This is the same word as in 1:7, "*a refuge in the day of distress*". The distress in which God was a refuge yesterday is the distress he brings to an end today.
- **One who counsels what is worthless (*yo'ets beliyya'al* – יֹעֵץ בְּלִיָּעַל, v. 11):** The Hebrew literally says a "*counsellor of worthlessness*". The word *beliyya'al* means "worthlessness", "lawlessness" or "destructive wickedness"; only later did it become a name, **Belial** (in the New Testament, 2 Corinthians 6:15, it is used as a name for Satan). The same word returns in 2:1 (English 1:15): "*For never again will the worthless one pass through you*".

- **Yoke and bonds (*motehu* – מֹטֵהוּ; *umoserotayikh* – וּמוֹסְרֹתַיִךְ, v. 13):** The "**yoke**" is the heavy wooden bar laid across the necks of oxen to control them and make them pull; the "**bonds**" are the leather straps that tied the yoke on.
- **You weigh nothing (*qallota* – קַלּוֹתָ, from *qalal*, v. 14):** *Qalal* means to be light, weightless, insignificant or contemptible. Our translation says *"for you weigh nothing"* – much like Daniel 5:27, where Belshazzar is weighed on the scales and found too light.
- **One who brings good news (*mevasser* – מְבַשֵּׂר, from *basar*, 2:1, English 1:15):** The Greek translation of the Old Testament renders this verb with *euangelizomai* – the word from which the New Testament idea of the *gospel* grows.
- **Peace (*shalom* – שָׁלוֹם, 2:1, English 1:15):** The message he cries out is **shalom**: peace, wholeness, restoration, safety.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The folly of conspiring against God (vv. 9–11):** Nahum opens verse 9 with a cutting rhetorical question to Assyria's leaders: *"What are you devising against the* LORD*?"* The Assyrians thought they were simply waging a geopolitical war against a little state called Judah. But Nahum reveals a deep spiritual truth: **to touch God's covenant people is to plot against God himself.**
    - The one *"who devises evil against the* LORD*"* (v. 11) is an Assyrian ruler who thought his power was greater than the Lord's – many interpreters think of King Sennacherib (and the spiritual powers behind him).
    - With striking images in verse 10 God shows how easily he breaks their resistance: even if the Assyrian armies are as impenetrable and dangerous as *"tangled thorns"*, and as reckless and drunk on their own success and wine as can be, before the fire of God's judgement they burn up in an instant like bone-dry stubble.

- Hence the powerful promise: "*distress will not rise up a second time*." When God finally deals with evil, his work is so complete that he does not need to come back a second time to finish it.

2. **The broken yoke and God's fatherly discipline (vv. 12–13):** In verse 12 God turns his face to his exhausted people, Judah, with words that fall like balm on an open wound: "*I have afflicted you; I will afflict you no more*." Here we see a key Old Testament principle: Assyria was merely a temporary instrument in God's hand to discipline Judah for its own idolatry and unfaithfulness (Isaiah 10:5 calls Assyria, literally, "*the rod of my anger*"). But the discipline has achieved its purpose, and the time of hardship is over. In verse 13 God promises: "*And now I will break his yoke from off you and tear your bonds apart*." God acts as the great Liberator who sets his children free from slavery and extortion.
3. **Found too light: the grave of idolatry and dynasty (v. 14):** Over against Judah's freedom stands the death sentence on the Assyrian royal house in verse 14. In the ancient world three things mattered supremely to a king: descendants to carry on his dynasty, the protection of his gods, and an honourable burial. God takes away all three:
   - **No descendants:** "*Nothing more will be sown that bears your name*" – the Assyrian empire and bloodline will die out completely.
   - **No gods:** God himself walks into the temples of Nineveh (such as those of their idols Ashur and Ishtar) to cut off "*carved image and cast image*". The gods they trusted cannot even save themselves.
   - **A grave of shame:** "*I will make your grave, for you weigh nothing*." The world thought Assyria was a heavyweight; on God's heavenly scales its pride weighs nothing.
4. **The feet on the mountains: the gospel of peace (2:1, English 1:15):** The passage closes with one of the most iconic images in the whole Bible: "*Look, on the mountains the feet of one who brings good news, who announces peace!*" In the ancient world there were no phones or internet. When a war was raging far away, the watchmen on Jerusalem's walls

stared anxiously at the surrounding hills and mountains. When a lone messenger came running over the ridge, the way he ran and the cry he gave decided whether the city would break out in mourning or in joy.

- This verse is almost word for word the same as Isaiah 52:7, and the apostle Paul quotes it in **Romans 10:15** to describe the preaching of the gospel of Jesus Christ.
- For Judah, the good news was that the Assyrian tyrant (*"the worthless one" / Belial*) had been defeated and they could once again travel freely to Jerusalem to keep their festivals and worship God. For us as New Testament believers it points to Jesus Christ, who defeated the ultimate *Belial* – sin, death and Satan – on the cross!

Living It Out

Nahum 1:9–2:1 (English 1:9–15) speaks directly to the person who is tired and worn out by a long struggle. Perhaps today you feel as if you have been walking for years under a heavy "yoke" – whether an ongoing emotional struggle, a toxic situation, an addiction, financial pressure or spiritual exhaustion.

This is how this passage renews us today:

- **God's "enough is enough":** Sometimes the enemy whispers to us that our present suffering or struggle will go on for ever and that we will never get free. Look again at God's words in verses 12 and 13: *"I will afflict you no more. And now I will break his yoke from off you …"* God knows our breaking point. Even when he allows hard seasons in our lives to shape our character and draw us closer to himself, every season of refining has an expiry date. When God says "enough", there is no power in the universe that can keep that yoke on your shoulders a moment longer.
- **Look at the heavenly scales, not at earthly appearances:** The problems, temptations or people that intimidate you often look like densely tangled thorns (v. 10) – impossible to break through and painful to

touch. But on God's scales they are *qalal* – they weigh nothing (v. 14). Don't let the noise and bluster of your challenges make you forget how weightless they are before God's almighty power.

- **Restore your worship and gratitude:** Notice the command to Judah as soon as the good news of peace arrives: "*Keep your festivals, Judah, pay your vows!*" (2:1, English 1:15). Oppression and fear steal our worship; they leave us spiritually paralysed. But the message of Christ's victory calls us back to a life of gratitude, joy and devotion. We don't have to wait until every problem in our life is perfectly solved before we praise God; we can celebrate today, because the Victor has already come over the mountains and secured our eternal *shalom*.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- What specific "yoke" or "bonds" (v. 13) – whether fear, guilt, a bad habit or a heavy burden you carry – feel right now like an Assyrian oppressor on your shoulders? How can you deliberately lay that yoke before the Lord today for him to break?
- Is there something in your life (or in the world) that looks to you like an impenetrable thicket of thorns (v. 10), to which you give more weight than to God's promises?
- In 2:1 (English 1:15) Judah is called to keep its festivals and pay its vows again. What would it look like in practice for you to live this week in "celebration and worship" as a response to the good news of Jesus' victory in your life?

Prayer

> *Lord my God, Breaker of every yoke and King of peace, I come to you today with a heart full of gratitude for the promises in your Word. Thank you that no power, no problem and no attack of the enemy is too big or too complicated for you. What looks to me like an impenetrable thicket of thorns is, before your holy presence, like dry stubble that vanishes in a moment.*

Father, you see the heavy yokes and the bonds that sometimes try to tie me down – the worries that drain my energy, the struggle that has gone on so long, and the fears that want to rob me of joy. Today I hold on to your powerful promise in Nahum 1:13: Break this yoke from off my neck and tear apart the bonds that hold me back! Thank you that distress will not last for ever and that your grace always has the last word.

Above all I thank you for the most beautiful feet on the mountains – my Lord Jesus Christ, who brought me the ultimate good news of eternal peace and salvation with his own blood. Because he has finally defeated the power of sin and death, I choose today to step out of the shadow of fear and to worship you with joy and abandon. Fill my heart and my home today with your perfect shalom. In Jesus' victorious name. Amen.

DAY 3

The Siege of Nineveh: When Human Power Collapses

SCRIPTURE

Nahum 2:2–8

2 One who scatters has come up against you.
Guard the rampart!
Watch the road!
Brace your loins!
Gather all your strength! (*English Bibles: 2:1; from here on subtract one from the verse number*)
3 For the LORD restores the majesty of Jacob
like the majesty of Israel;
for plunderers have plundered them
and ruined their vine branches.
4 The shield of his warriors is reddened,
the men of valour are clothed in scarlet;
the chariots flash with the fire of steel
on the day he makes ready,
and the cypress spears are brandished.
5 In the streets the chariots rage,
they rush to and fro in the squares;
their appearance is like torches,
like lightning they dart about.
6 He remembers his nobles;
they stumble as they go;
they hurry to her wall,
and the protective cover is set up.
7 The gates of the rivers are opened,
and the palace melts away.
8 And it is fixed: she is stripped, she is carried away,
and her slave women moan
like the sound of doves,
beating on their breasts.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

(A note on verse numbers: today's passage is 2:2–8 in the Hebrew text, which we follow; English Bibles number it 2:1–7. Subtract one from our verse number to find it in an English Bible.)

In chapter 1 Nahum announced *that* God would judge Nineveh. Now, in chapter 2, he shows *how* it will happen. This passage reads like a vivid eye-witness report of an ancient battle – but the remarkable thing is that Nahum probably wrote these words decades *before* Nineveh actually fell! In **612 BC** a coalition of Babylonians (under Nabopolassar) and Medes (under Cyaxares) besieged invincible Nineveh and destroyed it – and it happened as Nahum announces here.

Nineveh was an architectural and military marvel of the ancient world. Its inner city wall was some 12 kilometres long and very high – ancient writers describe it as so wide that three chariots could drive side by side on top of it. In places it was surrounded by a broad moat fed by the Tigris and the Khosr rivers. To any human observer, Nineveh was utterly untouchable.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **One who scatters (*mefits* – מֵפִיץ, v. 2, English 2:1):** "*One who scatters has come up against you.*" The Hebrew text reads *mefits*, "one who scatters"; some interpreters, with a small change, read "a shatterer" (a war club, cf. Jeremiah 51:20).
- **Majesty (*ge'on* – גְּאוֹן, v. 3, English 2:2):** "*For the* LORD *restores the majesty of Jacob*" – *ge'on* means majesty, honour or glory.
- **Scarlet and red (*magen ... me'oddam* – מָגֵן ... מְאָדָּם; *metulla'im* – מְתֻלָּעִים, v. 4, English 2:3):** The **shield** (*magen*) is reddened, and the soldiers are *metulla'im*, "clothed in scarlet" (from *tola'at*, the worm from which the scarlet dye was made).

- **The fire of steel (*peladot* – פְּלָדוֹת, v. 4):** A word found only here – flashing iron or fire-steel, the gleaming steel fittings of the chariots.
- **Nobles and protective cover (*addirav* – אַדִּירָיו; *hassokhekh* – הַסֹּכֵךְ, v. 6, English 2:5):** The *addirim* are the nobles and elite officers. The *sokhekh* is a covering: a mobile armoured roof or shield wall used in sieges.
- **Melts away (*namog* – נָמוֹג, from *mug*, v. 7, English 2:6):** To dissolve or collapse – the same verb used of the hills that "melt away" before the LORD in 1:5.
- **It is fixed (*wehutsav* – וְהֻצַּב, v. 8, English 2:7):** Literally "it has been set firm": Nineveh's fate is decided.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Divine irony against human pride (v. 2, English 2:1):** Nahum begins with biting, holy sarcasm aimed at Assyria's commanders: *"Guard the rampart! Watch the road! Brace your loins! Gather all your strength!"* The prophet dares Nineveh to put up its best defence, because *"one who scatters"* is on his way. Although the Babylonian and Median armies were the earthly instruments, the wider context of the book shows that God himself is the Commander-in-Chief behind this attack. Human preparation, however impressive, is useless when you are fighting against God's purpose.
2. **The spiritual reason for the judgement: restoring the vine (v. 3, English 2:2):** In the middle of the battle scene, verse 3 gives the deeper theological reason why Nineveh must fall: *"For the LORD restores the majesty of Jacob like the majesty of Israel"*. In the Bible Israel and Judah are often compared to a vine (Psalm 80:9–17, English 80:8–16; Isaiah 5:1–7). The Assyrian plunderers had trampled God's vineyard and *"ruined their vine branches"*. God's judgement on evil is never separate from his plan of salvation for his children. He breaks the oppressor's power so that his own people's spiritual heritage and dignity can be restored.

3. **The colours and speed of the attack (vv. 4–5, English 2:3–4):** With short, staccato phrases in the original Hebrew, Nahum creates the sound and motion of a charge:
   - **Scarlet and red (v. 4):** The soldiers – probably the attackers, though the Hebrew could also mean Nineveh's own warriors – wear scarlet clothing and red shields. Some interpreters think the Medes and Babylonians wore red to strike fear into their enemies, or to hide bloodstains during battle so that the enemy could not take heart when someone was wounded.
   - **Flashing chariots (v. 5):** The chariots with their gleaming steel fittings race through the streets and across the city's wide squares. What was once Nineveh's pride – its own swift chariots – is now turned against it, like torches and lightning darting to and fro in the night.
4. **Panic and the opening of the river gates (vv. 6–7, English 2:5–6):** In verse 6 the Assyrian king (if he is the one meant – the Hebrew could also refer to the attacker) desperately tries to summon his nobles and elite officers, but in their panic "*they stumble as they go*" on the way to the city walls, and "*the protective cover is set up*". Then comes the most remarkable prophecy, in **verse 7**: "*The gates of the rivers are opened, and the palace melts away.*"
   - The Babylonian chronicle of Nineveh's fall tells only of a three-month siege and the capture of the city. The later Greek historian Diodorus Siculus (drawing on older Greek sources), however, tells how heavy rains made the river burst its banks and how the floodwater brought down part of the city wall. Whether the sluices and water gates meant to protect the city gave way under the pressure or were manipulated by the attackers, we cannot know for sure.
   - If it happened that way, the floodwater literally made parts of Nineveh's mud-brick walls and foundations "melt away", so that the invading armies could storm into the city. However exactly it hap-

pened: what had been Nineveh's greatest natural protection (the rivers) became, in God's hand, the instrument of its downfall.

5. **From queen to slave (v. 8, English 2:7):** *"And it is fixed: she is stripped, she is carried away"*. The mighty city, which saw herself as an invincible queen and goddess (probably also a reference to the idol of Ishtar, Nineveh's patron goddess), is stripped and carried off into exile. Her slave women moan *"like the sound of doves, beating on their breasts"* – the soft, hopeless cooing of mourning doves. The roles are completely reversed: the city that carried nations away without mercy is now carried away herself.

Living It Out

At first glance Nahum 2:2–8 (English 2:1–7) looks like ancient war history, but the spiritual principles locked up in it speak powerfully to our inner life and our walk of faith today.

- **The fragility of false fortresses:** Nineveh put its trust in enormous walls and a clever system of river gates. Today we also build our own "walls of Nineveh" to make ourselves feel safe and in control – our bank accounts, our careers, our intellect, our physical strength or our reputation. But verse 7 (English 6) shows how quickly earthly security can "melt away" when the floodwaters of life rise. True security is never found in the walls *we* build, but only in the Refuge (Nahum 1:7) who is God himself.
- **God's promise of restoration for the ruined vine:** Look again at the beautiful promise in verse 3 (English 2): *"For the* LORD *restores the majesty of Jacob like the majesty of Israel; for plunderers have plundered them and ruined their vine branches."* Perhaps today you feel like that ruined vine. Perhaps hard seasons, hurts, your own mistakes or the attacks of life have plundered your joy, your gifts or your spiritual

strength. God sees the broken branches. His plan is not only to remove whatever is ruining you, but to **restore** your spiritual dignity, your fruitfulness and your calling in Christ.

- **No spiritual stronghold is untouchable for God:** Paul writes in 2 Corinthians 10:4 that the weapons of our warfare are powerful for God to tear down "strongholds". Sometimes there are spiritual strongholds – deep-rooted thought patterns, sins passed down through generations, bitterness or powerful temptations – that seem to us as high and invincible as Nineveh's walls. Nahum 2 reminds us that the "one who scatters" (v. 2, English 2:1) is mightier than any stronghold. When God opens the floodgates of his Spirit, the enemy's highest walls melt away like mud brick in a flood.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- Which human "walls" or forms of false security do you tend to lean on when you feel uncertain or threatened? What does Nineveh's "melting palace" (v. 7, English 6) teach you about where your true anchor must lie?
- Read verse 3 (English 2) again. In which area of your life do you feel that your "vine branches" have been plundered or ruined? How does it give you hope today to know that God is a God who restores the honour and fruitfulness of his children?
- Is there a stubborn "stronghold" (in your own thought life, your family, or a situation around you) that seems humanly impossible to break through? How does this chapter encourage you to pray about it with new faith?

Prayer

> *Almighty God and heavenly Father, before you the highest walls of human pride and the strongest fortresses of this world are like clay melting in water. I thank you for your Word, which shows that you are the Lord of history*

– what you speak, you bring to pass, and no power can hold back your hand.

Lord, forgive me for the times I build my own "walls" of self-sufficiency, earthly security or human control and think they will protect me. Help me to lay down every false prop and to put my whole trust in you alone, the eternal Rock.

Today I hold on especially to your precious promise in Nahum 2:3 (English 2:2). You see every place in my life and in my heart where the plunderers of this life – disappointment, sin, fear and exhaustion – have damaged my vine branches. I ask you, Lord of the harvest: restore what is broken! Let the floodgates of your Holy Spirit open over my life. Let every spiritual stronghold of fear, doubt or bondage melt away before your face, and let my life blossom again and bear fruit to the glory of your name. I pray this in the mighty and restoring name of Jesus Christ. Amen.

DAY 4

The Lions' Den Plundered – God Opposes the Proud

SCRIPTURE

Nahum 2:9–14

9 Nineveh is like a pool of water
all her days;
but now they are fleeing.
"Stop! Stop!" –
but no one turns back.
10 Plunder silver! Plunder gold!
There is no end to the treasure,
wealth heavy with every precious thing.
11 Empty! Emptied! Laid waste!
The heart melts, the knees knock,
trembling is in all loins,
and all their faces grow pale.
12 Where now is the lions' den,
the pasture of the young lions,
where the lion walked, the lioness,
there the lion's cub,
and no one made them afraid?
13 The lion tore enough for his cubs
and strangled prey for his lionesses;
he filled his holes with prey
and his dens with torn flesh.
14 Look, I am against you
– declares the LORD of hosts –
I will burn her chariots in smoke,
and the sword will devour your young lions;
I will cut off your prey from the earth,
and the voice of your messengers
will be heard no more.

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

(A note on verse numbers: today's passage is 2:9–14 in the Hebrew text, which we follow; English Bibles number it 2:8–13. In this chapter, subtract one from our verse number to find it in an English Bible.)

Yesterday, in the first half of chapter 2, we saw the invading armies storm into the city, the gates of the rivers opened and the palace melting away (2:7; English 2:6). Now, in verses 9 to 14 (English 8–13), Nahum takes us deeper into the falling city to watch the total collapse of its economy, its army and its national pride. The passage reaches a dramatic climax in one of the most powerful images in the Old Testament: the **lions' den** – *"the lions' den"* – that God himself silences.

For centuries the Assyrian kings used the lion as their chief royal symbol. Excavations at Nineveh (especially in the palaces of Sennacherib and Ashurbanipal) have uncovered many large stone reliefs showing Assyrian kings hunting and overpowering lions, and identifying themselves with the strength and ruthlessness of a predator. In their royal titles Assyrian kings compared themselves to lions – Ashurnasirpal II, for example, lists "lion" among his titles of self-praise. Nahum seizes this very national symbol and turns it against them with shocking poetic justice.

The burst dam and the endless plunder (vv. 9–10; English 8–9): Nahum compares Nineveh to *"a pool of water"* – a great reservoir. Through decades of conquest, tribute and trade, the wealth and people of the ancient world had flowed into Nineveh and been dammed up there. But now that the walls are broken, the reservoir is draining! Its inhabitants and mercenaries pour out of the city in blind panic like water through a burst dam wall. The commanders shout in desperation: *"Stop! Stop!"* (Hold your positions!) – *"but no one turns back."* In verse 10 (English 9) the attackers (the Medes and Babylonians) are urged to plunder the treasuries. For more than a century Assyria had robbed and hoarded the silver and gold of other na-

tions – including the treasures of the temple and palace in Jerusalem (2 Kings 18:14–16). Now its own bottomless treasuries are carried off in a single day.

The question history has answered (v. 12; English 11): When Nineveh fell in 612 BC, the destruction was so complete that the city never again became a capital; apart from small later settlements on the site, it decayed into mounds of ruins. When the Greek general Xenophon marched past the ruins of Nineveh with his army in 401 BC (a little over 200 years later), he apparently did not even recognise them as the mighty capital of Assyria – he does not even give its name! The question *"Where now is the lions' den"* has literally been answered by history.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **"Like a pool of water" (*kivrekhat mayim* – כִּבְרֵכַת מַיִם):** A *berekhah* is a large reservoir – a picture of the wealth and people that had pooled in Nineveh for centuries and are now draining away.
- **"Stop! Stop!" (*'imdu 'amodu* – עִמְדוּ עֲמֹדוּ):** Two commands in quick succession, like the cry of a commander trying to halt his fleeing troops.
- **The poetry of total devastation (*buqah umevuqah umevullaqah* – בּוּקָה וּמְבוּקָה וּמְבֻלָּקָה):** Verse 11 (English 10) contains one of the most brilliant sound plays (alliteration and assonance) in the whole Bible. Our translation tries to imitate it: *"Empty! Emptied! Laid waste!"*
  - The syllables build (from two, to three, to four), and the hard sounds in Hebrew sound like water glugging out of a bottle, or the rumble of walls collapsing. It paints a city completely shaken out, stripped and laid waste.
  - Look at what fear does physically to the once proud warriors: *"The heart melts, the knees knock, trembling is in all loins, and all their faces grow pale."* Their hearts melt (despair), their knees knock together, their loins (*motnayim* – מָתְנַיִם, the seat of physical strength in

Hebrew thought) convulse with spasms of anguish, and their faces grow pale (or flush with mortal terror). The terrorists of the ancient world are now overwhelmed by terror themselves.

- **Four words for lions (vv. 12–13; English 11–12):** In just two verses Nahum uses four different Hebrew words for lions: *aryeh* (אַרְיֵה) for the full-grown male lion, *kefirim* (כְּפִירִים) for the strong young hunting lions, *lavi* (לָבִיא) for the lioness, and *gur* (גּוּר) for the lion's cub.
- **"The LORD of hosts" (YHWH *Tseva'ot* – יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת):** The LORD who commands all the powers of heaven and earth.
- **"Your messengers" (*mal'akhekhe* – מַלְאָכֶיךָ):** The envoys of the Assyrian king – the very voices that had spread fear throughout the ancient world (see below).

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The taunt over the lions' den (vv. 12–13; English 11–12).** With cutting irony Nahum asks in verse 12: "*Where now is the lions' den*"? The image describes the Assyrian state down to the finest detail: its kings and generals hunted the earth like predators, "strangled" and "tore" nations, and brought the prey back to their "den" in Nineveh to feed their wives, princes and citizens in luxury – "*and no one made them afraid.*" But the God of Israel puts an end to the predator no one could stop.
2. **The most terrifying words in Scripture (v. 14; English 13).** The chapter ends with a divine indictment that should stop anyone in their tracks: "**Look, I am against you – declares the LORD of hosts.**" Up to this point in chapter 2 Nahum has described the fall of the city; now God himself takes the floor in the first person ("I"). The mighty lion of Assyria thought he stood above the law, but now he stands before the Creator of the universe – the LORD *of hosts*, who commands all the powers of heaven and earth.
3. **The fourfold sentence God carries out in person:**

- **The war machine is destroyed:** "*I will burn her chariots in smoke*." Their military technology goes up in flames.
- **The next generation of leaders falls:** "*The sword will devour your young lions*" – the elite soldiers and princes.
- **The exploitation ends:** "*I will cut off your prey from the earth*." Their economic imperialism and plundering are stopped for good.
- **The arrogant voice is silenced:** "*The voice of your messengers will be heard no more*." For generations Assyrian envoys (like the notorious Rabshakeh before the walls of Jerusalem in 2 Kings 18) travelled from city to city reading out threatening letters, demanding tribute and mocking the living God. God says: those intimidating voices will never be heard again!

Living It Out

Nahum 2:9–14 (English 2:8–13) confronts us with the great contrast between the kingdoms of this world (the "lions' den" mentality) and the kingdom of God. It holds deep lessons for the attitude of our hearts and for our faith today:

Guard against the "lions' den" mentality of pride and greed. Nineveh's whole existence was built on the principle of *grab, hoard and dominate at the expense of others* (vv. 10, 13; English 9, 12). We may not be ancient emperors, but we live in a culture that encourages us to build our own "lions' dens" – to pile up wealth, status and possessions as our main source of identity, often without caring who gets hurt along the way. But verses 9–11 (English 8–10) show where everything hoarded outside God's will ends: *buqah umevuqah umevullaqah – "Empty! Emptied! Laid waste!"* In Luke 12:15–21 Jesus warns us against the fool who fills barns with treasure for himself but is not rich towards God. True wealth is not found in what we "catch" for ourselves, but in what we receive by grace and give away as a blessing to others.

The awe of "I am against you" – and the wonder of "God is for us". There is no more frightening place in the universe than to hear, because of pride and an unrepentant heart, the LORD of hosts say: *"Look, I am against you"* (James 4:6: "God sets himself against the proud, but gives grace to the humble"). On the other hand, for the child of God who flees to Christ in humility, the exact opposite is true – the truth of Romans 8:31: "**If God is for us, who is against us?**" When we lay our pride down at the cross, the Judge of Nahum 2:14 (English 2:13) becomes our Protector and Advocate.

God silences the voice of the accuser. Look again at the last promise of verse 14 (English 13): *"and the voice of your messengers will be heard no more."* In our spiritual lives the enemy (who in 1 Peter 5:8 is also compared to a roaring lion) often sends his "messengers" into our thoughts – voices of intimidation, fear, condemnation, despair and doubt, which, like the Assyrian envoys, shout at you that you are defeated and that God cannot help you. Nahum reminds us that the Lion of the tribe of Judah (Revelation 5:5) is mightier than the roaring lion of darkness. God has the power to silence every intimidating voice of the enemy in your life for good!

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

1. Nineveh was like *"a pool of water"* (v. 9, English 8) and a treasury full of gold and silver (v. 10, English 9), but when the test came, everything drained away in a moment and left emptiness (*buqah*) behind. Are there earthly things in which you are seeking your emotional security right now that could leave you empty in the end?
2. Where in your own heart do you sometimes notice subtle signs of pride or selfishness – the desire to protect your own "lions' den" of comfort and recognition? How do James 4:6 and Nahum 2:14 (English 2:13) call you back today to true humility before the Lord?
3. Which "intimidating messengers" (thoughts of fear, old accusations or threatening circumstances) are loudest in your ears right now? How can you trust the LORD *of hosts* today to silence those voices within you?

Prayer

LORD of hosts, almighty King, before whom no earthly power and no proud lion can stand, I come before your throne today in deep humility. Your word in Nahum reminds me afresh how empty and passing the wealth, power and fame of this world are. Everything built up by human pride and greed ends in emptiness and ruin.

Father, search my heart today. Keep me from trying to build my own kingdom or "lions' den" at the expense of others or apart from you. Wherever even a trace of pride, selfishness or trust in earthly treasure has crept into my life, I confess it to you. I never want to stand where you must oppose me; I choose to humble myself under your mighty hand, knowing that through Jesus Christ you are for me and not against me.

Lord, thank you for the powerful promise in verse 14 (English 13) that you silence the voice of the enemy's messengers. Every voice of fear, intimidation, discouragement and accusation that shouts at my mind today I bring under the authority of the Lion of the tribe of Judah. Speak your peace over my thoughts, strengthen my knees when they want to knock, and fill my heart with unshakeable courage in your presence. In the name of Jesus Christ, my King and Victor. Amen.

DAY 5

Woe to the City of Bloodshed! Spiritual and Moral Corruption Exposed

SCRIPTURE

Nahum 3:1–7

[1] Woe to the city of bloodshed!
All of it is lies,
full of plunder;
the prey never departs.
[2] The crack of the whip
and the rumble of the wheel,
the galloping horse
and the jolting chariot!
[3] Horsemen charging,
the flame of the sword and the lightning of the spear,
a multitude of slain,
a heavy mass of corpses,
no end to the bodies –
they stumble over their bodies.
[4] All this because of the many harlotries of the prostitute,
lovely and charming,
mistress of sorceries,
who sells nations through her harlotries
and clans through her sorceries.
[5] Look, I am against you
– declares the LORD of hosts –
I will lift your skirts over your face
and let the nations see your nakedness
and the kingdoms your shame.
[6] I will throw filth on you,
treat you with contempt,
and make you a spectacle.
[7] And everyone who sees you
will flee from you and say:
"Nineveh is devastated!
Who will grieve for her?"
Where shall I seek comforters for you?

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

While chapter 2 focused on the physical and military collapse of Nineveh, chapter 3 takes us to the **moral and spiritual root** of her downfall. Why did God pronounce such a merciless judgement on this world city? In Nahum 3:1–7 the prophet pulls back the glittering curtain of Assyria's civilisation, architecture and diplomatic charm to show what God really sees: a city built on blood, deceit and occult manipulation.

The passage opens with the Hebrew cry *hoy!* ("Woe!"), which in the prophetic books is both an indictment and a funeral lament. For any nation or system that thinks success and power lift it above God's moral law, these seven verses are a sobering mirror.

The history behind the charges is well known. Assyrian kings such as Ashurnasirpal II and Sennacherib boasted in their inscriptions and palace reliefs of piling up heaps of severed heads in front of conquered cities and flaying captives alive to spread terror. Assyria's dealings with smaller nations were often a matter of promises and betrayal: when King Ahaz of Judah asked Assyria for help, Judah became a subject vassal paying heavy tribute (2 Kings 16:7–8; 2 Chronicles 28:20–21). And Nineveh was a major centre of the worship of **Ishtar** (the goddess of fertility, war and sexual licence), steeped in Babylonian-Assyrian occultism, divination and astrology.

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

In verse 1 Nahum sums up Nineveh's character in four sharp charges: *"Woe to the city of bloodshed! All of it is lies, full of plunder; the prey never departs."*

- **The city of bloodshed (*'ir damim* – עִיר דָּמִים):** Literally "city of blood" (plural: bloody deeds). Nineveh's whole economy and splendour had been bought with human blood.

- **All of it is lies (*kachash* – כָּחַשׁ):** *Kachash* means lies and deceit in general. Here it probably includes diplomatic deceit and false treaties – promises of friendship and protection that ended in slavery and heavy tribute.
- **Full of plunder (*pereq* – פֶּרֶק):** The word comes from *paraq*, to tear something off or rip it apart by force – plunder that goes hand in hand with violence. (It sounds like *perekh* – פֶּרֶךְ, the "harshness" with which Egypt made the Israelites work in Exodus 1:13, but it is a different root.)
- **The prey never departs (lo *yamish teref* – לֹא יָמִישׁ טֶרֶף):** Like a predator that is never satisfied, Nineveh never stopped exploiting weaker nations. God shows here that he records every drop of innocent blood and every broken promise in his heavenly ledger.
- **The soundtrack of judgement (vv. 2–3):** In the original Hebrew, verses 2 and 3 contain hardly any finite verbs or full sentences; they are a rapid-fire series of sound-painting nouns that put the reader right in the middle of the street fighting in Nineveh. You *hear* the crack of the rider's whip (*qol shot* – קוֹל שׁוֹט), the rumble of chariot wheels over the stone streets (*qol ra'ash ofan* – קוֹל רַעַשׁ אוֹפָן), the galloping of horses, and you *see* the flash of bronze and iron weapons in the sunlight.
- **"The prostitute, lovely and charming" (*zonah tovat chen* – זוֹנָה טוֹבַת חֵן) and "mistress of sorceries" (*ba'alat keshafim* – בַּעֲלַת כְּשָׁפִים):** A seductress of great grace and charm, and a woman who rules others by sorcery (v. 4).
- **Filth (*shiqqutsim* – שִׁקֻּצִים):** The word for "*filth*" in verse 6 refers specifically to **detestable, unclean things and idols**. She who adorned herself with gold and idols is now covered with her own spiritual filth and put on display (*kero'i* – כְּרֹאִי, "as a spectacle" – a public warning, a mark of shame) before the whole world.

- **Comforters (*menachamim* – מְנַחֲמִים):** Notice the deep wordplay on the prophet's own name in verse 7. The name **Nahum** (*Nachum* – נַחוּם) means "comfort" and comes from the same root as *menachamim*. The prophet brings rich comfort to God's oppressed people Judah, but for cruel, unrepentant Nineveh no comforter can be found.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The violence sown is reaped on their own doorstep (vv. 2–3).** The tragic irony of verse 3 is striking: the city that for centuries filled other cities' streets with corpses now has streets so full of the slain that "*they stumble over their bodies*." The violence they sowed they now reap on their own doorstep.

2. **The mask of the charming prostitute and sorceress (v. 4).** Why did so many nations fall into Assyria's trap? Verse 4 gives a brilliant psychological and spiritual explanation. Assyria conquered not only with the sword but by **seduction**. With impressive trade, luxury goods, powerful military alliances and an impressive culture, it lured smaller nations to trust in Assyria instead of God. (Think of how King Ahaz of Judah was so taken with the altar in Damascus that he altered the temple in Jerusalem to fit in with Assyria – 2 Kings 16:10–18.) But once a nation had been drawn in by her political and spiritual charm, she "*sold*" it – it lost its freedom and its soul and became a slave of the empire.

3. **God strips away the false glamour (vv. 5–7).** For the second time in the book, God's voice thunders in verse 5: "*Look, I am against you – declares the* LORD *of hosts*." In the ancient Near East, public exposure and humiliation was the punishment for a woman guilty of adultery and betrayal (compare Jeremiah 13:22, 26; Ezekiel 16:37). God uses this shocking image to show that he is going to strip off Nineveh's false royal robe of charm, power and invincibility.

4. **Those who live by intimidation die without comfort (v. 7).** The end of verse 7 is utter desolation: "*Who will grieve for her?" Where shall I seek comforters for you*? Those who live by intimidation and deceit have no

true friends when they fall.

Living It Out

Although Nineveh fell thousands of years ago, the *spirit of Nineveh* lives on in our modern world (and is portrayed in Revelation 17–18 as the end-time "Babylon the great prostitute"). This passage calls us to spiritual discernment and radical integrity in our daily walk:

Don't be deceived by the "lovely" charm of sin and worldly power. Verse 4 is one of the most accurate descriptions of how sin and temptation work. Sin never knocks on our door in its true form of emptiness, slavery and destruction (vv. 3, 6). It always arrives as something *"lovely and charming"* (*tovat chen*) – it promises pleasure, quick success, acceptance, security or control. It "bewitches" our minds into thinking that a compromise with the world will benefit us. But just like Nineveh, in the end it *sells* those who fall for it into slavery. Ask the Holy Spirit for eyes that can see past the shiny surface of temptation to where it leads.

Choose truth over a culture of lies. Nineveh built her empire on *kachash* – half-truths, manipulation and exploiting others for her own gain (v. 1). In our workplaces, businesses and relationships we often face pressure to bend the truth, manipulate people or step on others to get to the top. Nahum 3 reminds us that the LORD of hosts is a God of absolute truth and justice. Any success built on dishonesty or on wronging others already carries within it the seed of its own disgrace.

Build relationships on compassion, not on power. When Nineveh was in her deepest need, there was *no one* to grieve for her or comfort her (v. 7), because she had only used and abused everyone around her. That forces us to ask: how do we treat the people in our lives when we are in a position of strength or influence? Jesus teaches us that true greatness lies in serving, gentleness and sincere love.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

1. Look at the image in verse 4 of the "lovely" seduction that ends up enslaving people. Which worldly values, habits or temptations look attractive or harmless to you right now, but could steal your spiritual freedom and your close walk with God?
2. Nineveh was a city of which "*all of it is lies*" (v. 1), but in the end God exposed her for what she really was (v. 5). Is there any area of your life where you keep up an outward mask of success or religion, while you know the Lord is calling you to come before him in honesty and openness?
3. Verse 7 asks: "*Where shall I seek comforters for you?*" Nineveh had no comforter, but as a child of God you have the Holy Spirit – the true Comforter (*Parakletos*) – within you. How can you yourself be a voice of God's comfort and integrity this week for someone around you who has been hurt by the harshness of this world?

Prayer

> *Holy and righteous Father, you test hearts and minds, and before your eyes everything is laid bare and open. I bow before you in reverence today. Your word in Nahum 3 shows me that you are not impressed by the outward glamour, wealth or charm of this world. You see the truth behind every mask, and you hate the lies, the deceit and the violence that destroy people's lives.*
>
> *Lord, today I pray for spiritual discernment in my own life. Keep my heart and my eyes from being bewitched by the "lovely" lies of sin and worldly compromise. Where the enemy holds up temptations and false promises before me that glitter but lead into bondage, give me the wisdom and the strength of your Spirit to see the trap and flee from it.*
>
> *Cleanse my life of every form of dishonesty, hypocrisy and selfish ambition. I don't want to build my life on foundations that will be put to shame on the day of testing; I want to build it on the unshakeable rock of your truth, your*

integrity and your grace. Thank you that, while the world can offer no true comfort, you wrap me in the robe of Christ's righteousness and are my eternal Comforter. Lead me today on the path of uprightness and light. In the precious name of Jesus Christ. Amen.

DAY 6

The Final Fall of Oppression and Our Eternal Hope

SCRIPTURE

Nahum 3:8–19

[8] Are you better than No-Amon,
who sat by the channels of the Nile,
with water all around her,
whose rampart was the sea,
her wall from the sea?
[9] Cush was her strength, and Egypt,
and there was no end;
Put and the Libyans
were among your helpers.
[10] Yet she too went into exile,
she went into captivity;
her little children too were dashed to pieces
at the head of every street;
for her honoured men they cast lots,
and all her great men were bound in chains.
[11] You too will be drunk,
you will be hidden away;
you too will seek a refuge from the enemy.
[12] All your fortresses are fig trees
with first-ripe figs:
if they are shaken,
they fall into the mouth of the eater.
[13] Look, your people are women in your midst;
to your enemies the gates of your land
are thrown wide open;
fire has devoured your bars.
[14] Draw water for the siege!
Strengthen your fortresses!
Go into the clay
and tread the mortar!
Take hold of the brick mould!
[15] There the fire will devour you,
the sword will cut you off;

it will devour you like the hopper.
Make yourself many like the hopper,
make yourself many like the locust!
16 You have made your merchants more numerous
than the stars of the sky;
the hopper sheds its skin and flies away.
17 Your guards are like the locust,
your officials like a swarm of locusts
that settle in the walls
on a cold day;
when the sun rises, it flees,
and its place is not known – where are they?
18 Your shepherds slumber, king of Assyria;
your nobles lie down to rest;
your people are scattered on the mountains,
and there is no one to assemble them.
19 There is no easing for your fracture;
your wound is grievous.
All who hear the news of you
clap their hands over you;
for over whom has your evil not passed
continually?

Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today we reach the dramatic and moving close of the book of Nahum – and of our journey together. In these last twelve verses the prophet tears down the last illusion of Assyria's invincibility. To convince Nineveh that her fall is not merely possible but inevitable, Nahum uses a brilliant historical argument, followed by a series of vivid images from nature (ripe figs and locust swarms) and a final funeral lament over the king of Assyria.

This passage also gives us the most precise clue for dating the book. Because Nahum refers to the fall of the Egyptian city of No-Amon (Thebes) as something that has already happened, we know that he delivered his prophecy after 663 BC, when Assyria stood at the very peak of its world power.

The historical mirror of No-Amon / Thebes (vv. 8–10): Nahum asks a cutting rhetorical question: *"Are you better than No-Amon"*?

- **No-Amon** (in Hebrew literally "the city of the god Amun", ancient **Thebes** in Upper Egypt, today's Luxor) was for centuries the glittering religious and political capital of Egypt. It was surrounded by the broad Nile (poetically called "the sea" here) and a network of canals that served as natural moats – *"with water all around her, whose rampart was the sea"*. On top of that it had powerful African allies: Cush (Nubia, in today's Sudan), Egypt, Put (probably in Libya; some think of Punt on the Red Sea) and the Libyans.
- Yet in **663 BC** the Assyrian king Ashurbanipal achieved the unthinkable: he conquered No-Amon, plundered her temples and carried her nobles away in chains.

The king of Assyria (vv. 18–19): The book ends with a sombre epitaph addressed to the king of Assyria. When Nineveh fell in 612 BC, King Sin-shar-ishkun was reigning there; he probably perished with his city. (The story that the last king burned himself in the flames of his own palace comes from later Greek writers. A last Assyrian king, Ashur-uballit II, held out at Harran until about 609 BC.)

INSIGHTS FROM THE HEBREW

- **"A refuge" (*ma'oz* – מָעוֹז, v. 11):** Nineveh *"will seek a refuge from the enemy"* – the same word used in Nahum 1:7 to show that God alone is the true *ma'oz* for his children!

- **"First-ripe figs" (*bikkurim* – בִּכּוּרִים, v. 12):** The very first, early summer figs that ripen in June. These early figs were a prized delicacy and hung so loosely on the branches that the slightest shake of the tree dropped them straight into the mouth of the hungry picker.
- **Three words for locusts (vv. 15–17):** *yeleq* (יֶלֶק, "hopper" – the young, wingless stage that crawls and strips everything in its path), *arbeh* (אַרְבֶּה, "locust" – the adult, winged swarm that darkens the sun) and *gov* (גוֹב, v. 17, "swarm of locusts").
- **Merchants, guards and officials (vv. 16–17):** Nahum compares Nineveh's own **merchants** (*rokhlayikh* – רֹכְלַיִךְ), **guards** (*minnezarayikh* – מִנְזָרַיִךְ) and **officials** (*tafsarayikh* – טַפְסְרַיִךְ – an Assyrian loanword for high-ranking bureaucrats or scribes) to locusts.
- **"Your shepherds slumber" (*namu ro'ekha* – נָמוּ רֹעֶיךָ, v. 18):** The *"shepherds"* are the generals, advisers and rulers. That they *"slumber"* and the nobles *"lie down to rest"* is a poetic euphemism for the sleep of death.
- **"Your fracture … your wound" (*shivrekha* – שִׁבְרֶךָ; *nachlah makkatekha* – נַחְלָה מַכָּתֶךָ, v. 19):** *Nachlah* means "grievous, sick" – a wound that will not heal. Jeremiah 30:12 uses exactly the same expression for Judah's wound of sin.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **No city is untouchable (vv. 8–11).** Look at the prophet's masterly logic: Nineveh considered herself safe behind the waters of the Tigris and her military might. But Nahum says: *your own history proves that no city with rivers and armies is untouchable!* If invincible Thebes fell, Nineveh too will drink the cup of God's wrath and stagger drunk (v. 11), and look in vain for a *refuge*. The LORD alone is the refuge that does not fall.

2. **Ripe figs and paralysed defenders (vv. 12–14).** Against the massive border forts and mountain strongholds meant to guard Assyria's frontiers, God sets a simple farming image: "*All your fortresses are fig trees with first-ripe figs: if they are shaken, they fall into the mouth of the eater.*" Just as easily would Nineveh's outer fortresses fall before the Babylonian and Median armies.
    - In verse 13 the mighty Assyrian soldiers are described as men who have completely lost their fighting spirit and courage, while the strategic mountain passes and river gates of the land are "*thrown wide open*" and fire devours the wooden bars of the city gates.
    - Verse 14 is full of prophetic irony: "*Draw water for the siege! Strengthen your fortresses! Go into the clay and tread the mortar! Take hold of the brick mould!*" Nahum mockingly urges the inhabitants to make mud bricks at top speed to repair the breaches in their walls. But the water Nineveh trusted could not save her: in 2:7 (English 2:6) it is precisely "*the gates of the rivers*" that are opened, and according to later Greek writers a flood brought down part of the walls. Feverish human effort at the last minute cannot hold back what God has decided to tear down.
3. **The paradox of the locust swarm (vv. 15–17).** On the one hand, the enemy will devour Nineveh like a plague of locusts (v. 15a). On the other hand, Nineveh's own merchants, guards and officials are themselves like locusts. Why? When things were going well for Nineveh, her opportunistic merchants and mercenaries swarmed like locusts – "*more numerous than the stars of the sky*" – to profit from the city's plundered wealth (v. 16). But just as the hopper sheds its last skin, gets wings and flies away as soon as the land has been stripped bare, and just as locusts sit numb with cold on the stone walls on a chilly morning but vanish as soon as the sun rises (v. 17), so all Nineveh's allies, businessmen and officials will vanish without a trace as soon as the heat of war rises!

4. **Sleeping shepherds and the world's applause of relief (vv. 18–19).** Without leaders, the Assyrian people are scattered over the mountains like sheep without a shepherd: *"and there is no one to assemble them."* The final diagnosis in verse 19 is irrevocable: *"There is no easing for your fracture; your wound is grievous."*
    - The whole book ends with one of the few rhetorical questions with which a book of the Bible closes (along with Jonah 4:11!): **"All who hear the news of you clap their hands over you; for over whom has your evil not passed continually?"**
    - How remarkable this contrast between Jonah and Nahum is! The book of **Jonah** ends with God's question of grace over a repentant Nineveh: *"And should I not have pity on Nineveh, the great city"*? The book of **Nahum** ends about a century later with a question of righteous judgement over an unrepentant Nineveh. When the tyrant finally falls, no one weeps; the whole ancient world claps its hands in relief because God's justice has prevailed!

Living It Out

As we close the book of Nahum, these last verses leave us with deep lessons for our faith, our character and our eternal hope:

Don't lean on "fair-weather locusts". Nineveh thought she was strong because she was surrounded by thousands of merchants, officials and allies (vv. 16–17). But when the sun of trial beat down, they all spread their wings and flew away. Worldly friendships and systems built on self-interest, money, status or mere advantage vanish as soon as you land in a crisis. How different the Lord is! In Nahum 1:7 we read – the words that give this series its title: *"The* LORD *is good, a refuge in the day of distress"*. When the heat of life rises, God does not fly away; he draws all the closer to those who shelter in him.

Sleeping shepherds and the Good Shepherd. Verse 18 shows the tragedy of earthly leaders ("shepherds") who fail in the hour of need, slumber and leave their people scattered. It lifts our eyes to the true Shepherd of Israel. Psalm 121:4 assures us: "Look, he does not slumber and does not sleep, the keeper of Israel." And in John 10:11–12 Jesus says that the hired hand runs away when he sees the wolf coming (just like Nineveh's officials), but that he is the **Good Shepherd** who lays down his life for the sheep and will never leave them scattered or alone.

The healing of our incurable wound, and our eternal hope. For proud, unrepentant Nineveh the final word was: *"your wound is grievous"* – a wound without healing (v. 19). In ourselves, our spiritual wound of sin was incurable too (Jeremiah 30:12, 17). But on the cross of Golgotha Jesus Christ took the judgement and the "fracture" upon himself, so that through his wounds complete healing could come to us (Isaiah 53:5)! What is more, the clapping of hands in verse 19 reminds us of the end of history in **Revelation 18 and 19**: a day is coming when all evil, all pain, all injustice and every form of darkness will be finally destroyed by Christ – and all heaven and earth will burst out in jubilant praise and relief, because God reigns for ever!

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

1. In verse 14 Nineveh feverishly tried in her own strength to tread the mortar and take hold of the brick mould to save her crumbling walls, instead of humbling herself before God. Where in your life are you trying right now to "bake bricks" in your own strength to control a situation you really need to surrender to the Lord?
2. Have you ever experienced earthly supports or people (like the locusts in v. 17) disappearing when the sun of trial rises? How does that experience help you rest more deeply in the faithfulness of the Good Shepherd, who never slumbers or flies away?

3. As you look back over our whole six-day journey through the book of Nahum (chapters 1 to 3), which one truth about who God is has touched your heart most deeply or brought you the most comfort (*nachum*)?

Prayer

Sovereign Lord, King of the ages and Judge of all the earth, at the end of this journey through the book of Nahum I bow before you in deep worship. Over these six days your word has shown me how mighty, how holy and how unshakeably just you are. Empires come and go, proud fortresses fall like ripe figs, and worldly allies fly away like locusts in the sun – but your throne stands firm for all eternity!

Father, thank you that you are not a shepherd who slumbers or sleeps like the leaders of this world. Thank you, Lord Jesus, that you are my Good Shepherd, who never leaves me when crisis strikes. When my own spiritual wound of sin was, humanly speaking, incurable, you let yourself be broken on the cross so that I could be made whole, forgiven and saved.

Help me to keep the lessons of Nahum deep in my heart. Never let me put my trust in human "mud bricks", earthly wealth or passing power. Today I choose afresh to anchor my life in the truth of Nahum 1:7: you are good, you are my only true refuge in the day of distress, and you know me by name. Give me the courage and faith to look ahead with hope, in the sure knowledge that all evil and hardship have an expiry date and that your justice and peace will win the final victory. To you belong all praise, honour and glory, now and for ever. Amen.

The whole book of Nahum

The complete text of Nahum in the translation used in these devotionals.

Chapter 1

[1] An oracle concerning Nineveh. The book of the vision of Nahum the
Elkoshite.

[2] A jealous God, one who takes vengeance, is the LORD;
the LORD takes vengeance and is full of wrath.
The LORD takes vengeance on his adversaries
and holds it against his enemies.
[3] The LORD is slow to anger and great in power,
and the LORD will surely not acquit the guilty.
In whirlwind and in storm is his way,
and clouds are the dust of his feet.
[4] He rebukes the sea and makes it dry,
and all the rivers he dries up.
Bashan and Carmel wither,
and the blossom of Lebanon withers.
[5] The mountains shake because of him,
and the hills melt away;
the earth rises up before his face,
the world and all who live in it.
[6] Before his fury who can stand?
Who can rise up against his burning anger?
His wrath pours out like fire,
and the rocks are torn down by him.
[7] The LORD is good,
a refuge in the day of distress;
he knows those who shelter in him.
[8] But with a flood that passes over
he will make a full end of her place,
and his enemies he will pursue into darkness.
[9] What are you devising against the LORD?

He is making a full end;
distress will not rise up a second time.
10 For even if they are like tangled thorns
and drunk as with their drink,
they are devoured like dry stubble, completely.
11 From you has come out
one who devises evil against the LORD,
one who counsels what is worthless.
12 Thus says the LORD:
Though they are at full strength and ever so many,
even so they will be shorn and pass away.
I have afflicted you;
I will afflict you no more.
13 And now I will break his yoke from off you
and tear your bonds apart.
14 But concerning you the LORD has commanded:
Nothing more will be sown that bears your name.
From the house of your gods I will cut off
carved image and cast image;
I will make your grave,
for you weigh nothing.

Chapter 2

1 Look, on the mountains
the feet of one who brings good news,
who announces peace!
Keep your festivals, Judah,
pay your vows!
For never again will the worthless one
pass through you;
he is cut off completely. (*English Bibles*: 1:15)
2 One who scatters has come up against you.
Guard the rampart!
Watch the road!
Brace your loins!

Gather all your strength! (*English Bibles: 2:1; from here on subtract one from the verse number*)
[3] For the LORD restores the majesty of Jacob
like the majesty of Israel;
for plunderers have plundered them
and ruined their vine branches.
[4] The shield of his warriors is reddened,
the men of valour are clothed in scarlet;
the chariots flash with the fire of steel
on the day he makes ready,
and the cypress spears are brandished.
[5] In the streets the chariots rage,
they rush to and fro in the squares;
their appearance is like torches,
like lightning they dart about.
[6] He remembers his nobles;
they stumble as they go;
they hurry to her wall,
and the protective cover is set up.
[7] The gates of the rivers are opened,
and the palace melts away.
[8] And it is fixed: she is stripped, she is carried away,
and her slave women moan
like the sound of doves,
beating on their breasts.
[9] Nineveh is like a pool of water
all her days;
but now they are fleeing.
"Stop! Stop!" –
but no one turns back.
[10] Plunder silver! Plunder gold!
There is no end to the treasure,
wealth heavy with every precious thing.
[11] Empty! Emptied! Laid waste!
The heart melts, the knees knock,

trembling is in all loins,
and all their faces grow pale.
12 Where now is the lions' den,
the pasture of the young lions,
where the lion walked, the lioness,
there the lion's cub,
and no one made them afraid?
13 The lion tore enough for his cubs
and strangled prey for his lionesses;
he filled his holes with prey
and his dens with torn flesh.
14 Look, I am against you
– declares the LORD of hosts –
I will burn her chariots in smoke,
and the sword will devour your young lions;
I will cut off your prey from the earth,
and the voice of your messengers
will be heard no more.

Chapter 3

1 Woe to the city of bloodshed!
All of it is lies,
full of plunder;
the prey never departs.
2 The crack of the whip
and the rumble of the wheel,
the galloping horse
and the jolting chariot!
3 Horsemen charging,
the flame of the sword and the lightning of the spear,
a multitude of slain,
a heavy mass of corpses,
no end to the bodies –
they stumble over their bodies.
4 All this because of the many harlotries of the prostitute,

lovely and charming,
mistress of sorceries,
who sells nations through her harlotries
and clans through her sorceries.
5 Look, I am against you
– declares the LORD of hosts –
I will lift your skirts over your face
and let the nations see your nakedness
and the kingdoms your shame.
6 I will throw filth on you,
treat you with contempt,
and make you a spectacle.
7 And everyone who sees you
will flee from you and say:
"Nineveh is devastated!
Who will grieve for her?"
Where shall I seek comforters for you?
8 Are you better than No-Amon,
who sat by the channels of the Nile,
with water all around her,
whose rampart was the sea,
her wall from the sea?
9 Cush was her strength, and Egypt,
and there was no end;
Put and the Libyans
were among your helpers.
10 Yet she too went into exile,
she went into captivity;
her little children too were dashed to pieces
at the head of every street;
for her honoured men they cast lots,
and all her great men were bound in chains.
11 You too will be drunk,
you will be hidden away;
you too will seek a refuge from the enemy.

[12] All your fortresses are fig trees
with first-ripe figs:
if they are shaken,
they fall into the mouth of the eater.
[13] Look, your people are women in your midst;
to your enemies the gates of your land
are thrown wide open;
fire has devoured your bars.
[14] Draw water for the siege!
Strengthen your fortresses!
Go into the clay
and tread the mortar!
Take hold of the brick mould!
[15] There the fire will devour you,
the sword will cut you off;
it will devour you like the hopper.
Make yourself many like the hopper,
make yourself many like the locust!
[16] You have made your merchants more numerous
than the stars of the sky;
the hopper sheds its skin and flies away.
[17] Your guards are like the locust,
your officials like a swarm of locusts
that settle in the walls
on a cold day;
when the sun rises, it flees,
and its place is not known – where are they?
[18] Your shepherds slumber, king of Assyria;
your nobles lie down to rest;
your people are scattered on the mountains,
and there is no one to assemble them.
[19] There is no easing for your fracture;
your wound is grievous.
All who hear the news of you
clap their hands over you;

for over whom has your evil not passed
continually?